Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Ruth Fainlight's "Crocuses"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used in a discussion of the tonal shift in Ruth Fainlight's "Crocuses" include

auditory imagery,
cognitive dissonance,
diction,
dissonance,
enjambment,
irony,
melopoeia,
onomatopoeia,
polysyndeton,
rhythm,
sigmatism,
stanza,
synæsthesia,
syntax,
tactile imagery,
tone, and
visual imagery.

The contestant should comment on the disconnect between the title and the overall effect of Fainlight's "Crocuses." The title, in retrospect, heralds the tonal shift that occurs across the enjambment that unites stanzas three and four. The momentary—and untroubling—anticipatory shiftings in visual imagery that are anchored in the diction sequences "pale, bare, tender" and muddy winter-faded" are followed by the subtle synæsthesia of "shivering petals" (shivering moving from the visual imagery dominating the first half of the poem to the auditory of the second half), the poem's shifting to imagery that is, in its finality, a painfully auditory underscoring the tonal shift.

The natural beauty of a scene that elicits a sense of tranquility, if not a sense of innocence-not-quite Edenic, shifts, as people are herded toward a dissonance that overwhelms in the suddenness of the onomatopoeic immediacy of *crack* and the onomatopoeic finality of the paced (*via* polysyndeton) *screams* and *prayers* and *moans*.

The writer, sensitive to the possibilities of "how way leads on to way" (Frost, "Road Not Taken"), might draw a parallel that begins with the naturalness of the cycle of life and death (the crocuses and the fading grass) and ends with the violent intrusion that is humanity's propensity to ensure that life finds an unnaturally tragic end.